These results support the idea that Trump's communication strategy was a deliberate attempt to undermine the global trade regime rather than a response to actual changes in trade behavior. Trump's toxic communication had far-reaching consequences. By consistently alleging widespread cheating, he fostered a climate of mistrust, leading other countries to question the fairness of the system and, in some cases, preemptively violate trade rules. Moreover, his rhetoric likely emboldened other populist leaders to adopt similar tactics, further eroding the credibility of global trade institutions.

While this analysis focuses on Trump, the findings have broader implications. Populists across the ideological spectrum use similar strategies to delegitimize IOs, exacerbating challenges to global governance. In subsequent chapters we explore how IOs adapt to counter these rhetorical attacks, seeking to maintain their legitimacy and operational capacity.

3.4 Conclusion

This chapter explored the multifaceted ways in which populists challenge IOs, grounding these dynamics in their historical context and providing empirical evidence. Our analysis revealed that populist leaders systematically disengage from IOs like the IMF, withhold critical information from institutions such as the World Bank, and deploy toxic rhetoric to undermine the global trade regime.

The findings highlight the pervasive nature of populist resistance to IOs. This hostility does not single out individual organizations, instead often spilling over to weaken support for global governance as a whole. By attacking the very principles of international cooperation, populists sow doubt about the viability of international laws and norms, fostering broader skepticism about globalization. Many populists deride "globalists" and the global order at large, further entrenching resistance to IOs beyond specific grievances. This underscores the significant threat populist intransigence poses, especially when the populist leader hails from a powerful member state with the ability to significantly disrupt an IO's functioning.

Yet, as we will show, IOs are not passive actors in this battle. They adapt, innovate, and push back, employing strategies designed to counter populist resistance and protect the global architecture from being dismantled. These